Encore — Full System Brief

Oct 12, 2026 · @Hopp

Executive summary

Encore is an AI programming director that fills a venue's empty nights, using Qloo's taste data to decide what to run and then executing it. A bar, café, restaurant or small music venue enters its address and its slow night. Encore reads the neighbourhood's taste, finds what nobody nearby is offering, invents a recurring event backed by evidence, finds the talent, produces the launch kit, and measures who actually came.

One line: Qloo knows what a neighbourhood loves. Encore turns that into people through the door on a Tuesday.

Why it wins:

- **It shows the hackathon's thesis on screen.** A "Generic AI vs Encore" toggle runs the same venue twice. A plain LLM suggests trivia night; Encore suggests a specific night with affinity scores behind every claim.
- **Qloo is the engine, not decoration.** Location insights, demographics, cross-domain affinity, entity search and popularity all drive decisions.
- **It closes the loop.** Decide, execute, promote, measure, improve. Other tools do one of those steps.
- **It is a real business.** Venues already pay for promotion, booking and POS software. Encore sells the missing piece: knowing what to run.
- **It avoids crowded categories.** Travel planners, restaurant finders, gift and playlist bots will flood the gallery. Encore serves the venue owner, not the consumer.

Hackathon facts: submissions close Oct 30, 2026, 11:45 pm EDT (Oct 31, 6:45 am Nairobi). Target submission: Oct 29. Judging Nov 2–16, winners Nov 23. First prize $15,000.

The problem

Most small venues are busy two or three nights a week and run near-empty on the rest, while rent, staff and stock cost the same every night. The fix everyone reaches for is an event, but owners pick it by guesswork.

- **They don't know their neighbourhood's taste.** They know their regulars, not the thousands of people within walking distance who never come in.
- **They copy what's nearby.** Four bars on one street all run trivia, so none of them wins Tuesday.
- **Generic AI makes it worse, not better.** Ask any chatbot and it suggests the same safe ideas for every postcode: trivia, karaoke, open mic.
- **Execution is the second wall.** Even with a good idea, the owner still has to find a performer, design a poster, write posts and get the word out, usually alone.
- **Nobody measures it.** Nights are judged on gut feel, so good ideas get dropped too early and bad ones run too long.

The result: owners lose money on dead nights, local performers miss paid gigs, and neighbourhoods have less to do. Encore attacks all three.

The solution: the owner's journey end to end

The owner spends about two minutes on input and gets a ready-to-run 4-week event series back. Worked example: **The Copper Room, a bar in Brooklyn. Tuesdays are dead.**

1. **Set up (2 minutes).** The owner gives the address, the slow night, a break-even headcount ("I need 40 people"), what the space can host (stage, screen, sound, kitchen) and a talent budget. Google Places fills in type, hours and photos automatically.
2. **Watch the agent think (about 60 seconds).** A live trace shows each step: reading the neighbourhood, checking competitors, generating concepts. Every finding carries its source.
3. **Pick a concept.** Three concept cards appear, each with a name, a one-line pitch, evidence chips ("Afrobeats 3.4× affinity within 2 km"), a fit score, estimated cost and a reason it beats what's nearby.
4. **Review the series plan.** The chosen concept becomes 4 weekly dates on a calendar, each with a variation so regulars keep coming back.
5. **Book talent.** Encore shortlists performers whose fan base overlaps this audience, at the right popularity tier, and drafts a personal outreach message for each.
6. **Launch.** One click produces the event page with RSVP and QR code, a poster, posts for Instagram, Facebook, TikTok and Google Business Profile, themed menu specials and an ad targeting brief.

7. **Run the night.** Guests scan the QR code at the door to check in. The owner logs spend if they want.
8. **Learn.** After each night Encore compares turnout with the break-even target and adjusts the next date: keep, tweak or swap the concept.

The owner never faces a blank page. Every step ends in something they can approve, edit or send.

Feature set

Core features ship by Oct 26; wow features make the demo unforgettable; roadmap features are written up but not built.

Feature	What it does	Tier	Status
Venue onboarding	Address autocomplete, slow night, break-even, capabilities, budget	Core	Hackathon
Neighbourhood taste profile	Qloo location + demographic insights across 8+ domains, shown as a "taste fingerprint"	Core	Hackathon
Competitor gap scan	Nearby venues (Google Places) and nearby events (Ticketmaster) on that night	Core	Hackathon
Concept generator	3 scored concepts from cross-domain affinity overlaps	Core	Hackathon
Evidence chips	Every claim links to the Qloo result behind it; no number without a receipt	Core	Hackathon
Live agent trace	Streams each step and finding as the agent works	Core	Hackathon
4-week series calendar	Turns one concept into a recurring series with weekly variations	Core	Hackathon
Launch kit	Poster, social posts, menu specials, event description	Core	Hackathon

Feature	What it does	Tier	Status
Event page + RSVP + QR	Public page per night, RSVP capture, door check-in	Core	Hackathon
Generic AI vs Encore toggle	Same venue, plain LLM answer beside Encore's evidence-backed answer	Wow	Hackathon
Talent finder + outreach	Performers with audience overlap at the right popularity tier; drafted messages	Wow	Hackathon
Ad targeting brief	Qloo affinities translated into Meta/TikTok interest targeting and radius	Wow	Hackathon
Learning loop	Check-ins vs break-even adjust the next date	Wow	Hackathon (light)
Preloaded demo venues	3 real US neighbourhoods, results instant, no signup	Wow	Hackathon
Auto-posting to Meta / Google	Publishes posts directly	Roadmap	After
POS integration (Toast, Square)	Real spend per night instead of check-ins only	Roadmap	After
Talent marketplace + payments	Book and pay performers inside Encore	Roadmap	After
Multi-venue dashboard	Groups, hotels, stadiums plan across sites	Roadmap	After
Brand sponsorship matching	Brands sponsor nights whose audience matches theirs	Roadmap	After

How the agent plans

Encore runs a fixed pipeline of six steps, and Claude chooses which tools to call inside each step. A fixed spine keeps runs fast and predictable for judges; tool choice inside each step keeps it genuinely agentic.

1. **Scout the venue.** Google Places resolves the address to coordinates, venue type, hours, rating and photos.
2. **Read the neighbourhood.** Qloo insights are queried with the venue's location and a radius (default 2 km) across artists, films, TV, brands, places, books, podcasts and tags, plus the area's demographic skew. The output is a taste fingerprint: the top over-indexing entities and tags per domain, with affinity scores.
3. **Find the gap.** Google Places lists nearby competing venues; Ticketmaster's Discovery API lists events nearby on the target weekday. Claude extracts what themes are already covered so concepts avoid them.
4. **Generate concepts.** Claude combines two or three high-affinity signals from different domains into a night concept, then re-queries Qloo with those signals to confirm the overlap is real. It produces 6 candidates internally and keeps the top 3.
5. **Score and explain.** Each concept gets a score from the formula below. Each evidence chip stores the Qloo request and response it came from.
6. **Plan and equip.** The chosen concept becomes a 4-week series, talent shortlist, launch kit and ad brief.

Concept score (0–100):

```
Score = 40 \cdot AudienceFit + 20 \cdot Novelty + 20 \cdot VenueFit + 20
\cdot CostFit
```

- **AudienceFit** = normalised Qloo affinity of the concept's signals in this area.
- **Novelty** = 1 minus overlap with themes found in the gap scan.
- **VenueFit** = how well the concept matches the space (stage, screen, kitchen, capacity).
- **CostFit** = estimated talent and setup cost against the owner's budget.

The grounding rule. Claude may only state a number that exists in a stored Qloo response. A validator checks every evidence chip against its response before the card is shown. If a claim has no receipt, it is dropped. This is the technical answer to "how do we know it isn't making this up?"

Source	Used for	Access
Qloo Insights API	Taste fingerprint, affinities, demographics, talent candidates, concept validation	Hackathon API key

Source	Used for	Access
Google Places API	Venue details, nearby competitors	Paid, free monthly credit
Ticketmaster Discovery API	Nearby events on the target night	Free key
Claude API	Orchestration, concept writing, copy, outreach drafts	Paid
Owner input	Slow night, break-even, capabilities, budget, past turnout	Form

Exact Qloo parameters (entity types, location filters, demographic outputs) get confirmed in the day-1 API test before the pipeline is coded.

Getting people in: distribution and measurement

An idea fills nothing until people hear about it, so Encore treats promotion as part of the plan, not an afterthought. Six channels, each generated from the same taste fingerprint so the message matches the audience.

Channel	What Encore produces	Hackathon
Event page	Public page per night with RSVP, add-to-calendar and share links	Live
Social posts	Captions and visuals for Instagram, Facebook, TikTok, Google Business Profile, written in the audience's references	Copy-ready
Paid ads brief	Interest targeting from Qloo affinities ("fans of X + Y"), radius, age band, suggested daily budget	Copy-ready
Performer promo kit	A share pack for the booked performer so their followers become guests	Copy-ready
Partner cross-promo	Local brands the audience over-indexes on, with a co-host pitch	Copy-ready
Regulars	SMS/email text for the venue's existing list	Copy-ready

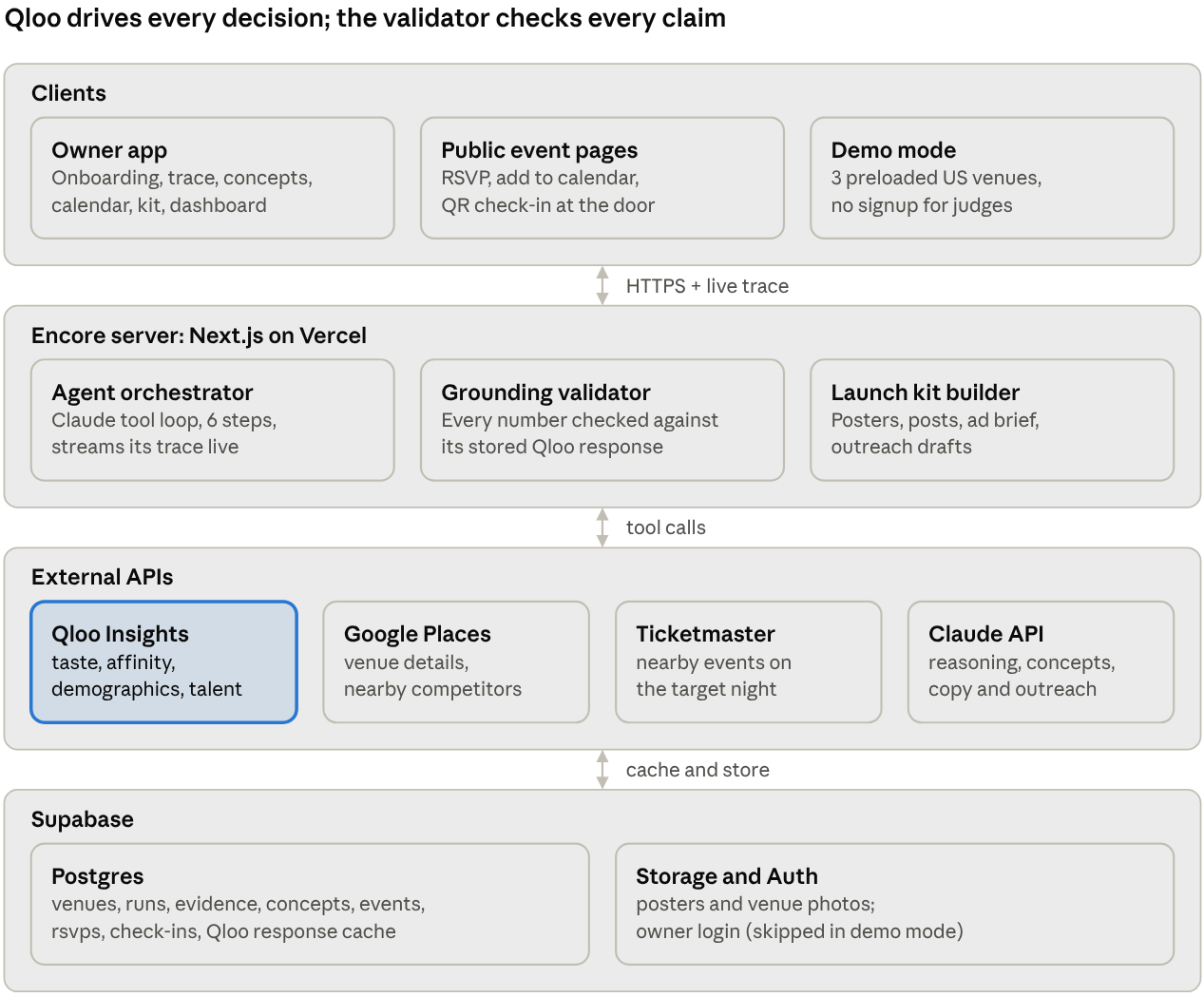
Measurement. Every RSVP and every QR check-in at the door is recorded per night. The dashboard shows RSVPs, check-ins, show-up rate and distance to break-even. This gives three things at once:

- **For the owner:** proof the night is working, or an early signal to change it.
- **For the learning loop:** the next date in the series adapts to what actually happened.
- **For the business:** a growing record of which concepts filled seats in which kinds of neighbourhoods. Nobody else has this outcome data.

Direct auto-posting to Meta and Google needs app review, so it stays on the roadmap. In the demo, every asset is one tap from being copied or shared.

System architecture

Encore is one Next.js app on Vercel backed by Supabase, built on Hopp's existing stack so all 18 days go to product, not setup.



Encore architecture · 4 layers

Requests flow down from the clients to the agent, out to four APIs, and every Qloo response is cached in Postgres so evidence chips can always point back to their source.

Data model

Table	Holds
venues	Address, coordinates, type, capacity, capabilities, slow night, break-even, budget
agent_runs	One planning run per venue and night, with status and timing

Table	Holds
run_steps	Each step's tool, input, summarised output and latency, for the live trace
qloo_cache	Request hash, full response, fetch time (7-day reuse)
concepts	Name, pitch, the four sub-scores and total score
evidence	Claim text, value, and the qloo_cache row that proves it
series / event_nights	Dates, weekly variation, generated assets, public slug
talent_candidates	Qloo entity, popularity tier, overlap score, outreach draft
rsvps / checkins	Guest name or phone, timestamp, night

Engineering decisions

- **Models:** Claude Sonnet 5.5 for orchestration and concept reasoning; Claude Haiku 5.5 for bulk copy (posts, captions, outreach) to keep cost and latency down.
- **Long runs:** each pipeline step is its own server call, driven from the client and streamed, so no single function hits Vercel's time limit.
- **Posters without an image model:** designed HTML/SVG templates rendered to PNG with Satori, filled with the concept's name, palette and copy. Fast, consistent and on-brand.
- **Speed for judges:** demo venues are precomputed and cached; a fresh run on a new address takes about a minute.
- **Abuse and cost control:** per-IP rate limits on fresh runs; Qloo responses reused from cache.
- **Open source:** MIT licence; API keys only in environment variables.

Uniqueness and competitive landscape

Every existing tool covers one step of the venue's problem; Encore is the only one that covers decide, execute, promote and measure in one loop.

Tool type	Example	Decides what to run	Executes	Promotes	Measures	Uses neighbourhood taste data
General chat assistants	ChatGPT, Gemini	Generic ideas	No	Drafts only	No	No
Ticketing platforms	Eventbrite, Dice	No	Listing	Yes	Ticket sales	No
POS and analytics	Toast, Square	No	No	No	Sales	No
Social schedulers	Buffer, Later	No	No	Yes	Engagement	No
Booking marketplaces	GigSalad	No	Talent only	No	No	No
Encore		**Evidence-backed**	**Talent, assets, plan**	**Yes**	**Check-ins**	**Yes, via Qloo**

What makes it unique:

- **It serves the supply side.** Almost every taste-AI product recommends places to consumers. Encore helps the place become worth recommending.
- **Cross-domain concepts.** Qloo's real power is linking music, film, food and brands. Encore's concepts are built from those links, which no single-domain tool can produce.
- **Receipts on every claim.** The grounding rule makes the output auditable, which is rare in agent demos.
- **Outcome data moat.** Check-ins tie taste to real attendance. Over time Encore learns which taste signals actually convert, which Qloo alone does not capture.

How to protect the edge before Oct 30: run Encore at one or two real venues, even small ones, and put the real check-in numbers in the submission. An idea can be repeated; a real pilot result cannot be copied in time.

Business model and path to enterprise

Encore starts as low-cost SaaS for single venues and grows into the programming layer for hospitality groups, venues and brands. Prices below are planning assumptions to test, not validated figures.

Stage	Customer	Revenue	Why they pay
1. Self-serve SaaS	Independent bars, cafés, restaurants, small venues	$49–99 per venue per month	One extra busy night a month covers the cost
2. Performance pricing	Same venues, opt-in	Small fee per checked-in guest above their baseline	Pay only for results
3. Talent marketplace	Venues and performers	Commission on bookings made through Encore	One place to find, book and pay talent
4. Enterprise	Hospitality groups, hotel chains, malls, stadiums and arenas	Annual contracts, multi-site dashboard	Programme off-days across many sites
5. Brand sponsorships	Consumer brands	Fee per sponsored night or campaign	Proven audience match plus real attendance

Unit logic for the pitch. A venue that adds 30 guests to one weekly night, at roughly $20 spend each, gains about $2,400 a month. Against a $49–99 subscription, the return is obvious. The demo should show this calculation from the owner's own break-even input.

Moat over time:

- Outcome data: which taste signals actually convert into attendance, by neighbourhood type.
- Network effects: more venues bring more performers, which bring better booking options for every venue.
- Switching cost: series history, regulars and performer relationships live in Encore.

Go-to-market: start with venue clusters in a few US cities, partner with local performer collectives, and sell through POS and hospitality software integrations. Kenya and other markets follow once Qloo's location coverage there is confirmed.

Hackathon fit

Encore meets every stated requirement and is designed around each judging criterion. Requirements below come from the hackathon summary; the official rules still need a full read on day 1.

Requirements

- [ ] Working, publicly accessible app (hosted on Vercel, no local-only demo)
- [ ] Public source repository with an open-source licence (MIT)
- [ ] Written explanation of functionality and Qloo integration
- [ ] Video: not required, but a 2-minute walkthrough is planned anyway
- [ ] Confirm eligibility for residents of Kenya and how prizes are paid
- [ ] Confirm whether work must start after Sep 30 and how Qloo API access is granted

Judging criteria

Criterion	How Encore scores	Proof in the demo
Technological implementation	Multi-step agent with tool use, streaming trace, grounding validator, caching, 4 external APIs	Live trace; evidence chip opens its Qloo response
Product design	Two-minute onboarding, preloaded venues, one-tap launch kit, mobile-first	Judge gets a full plan without signing up
Potential impact	Real money for small venues, paid gigs for local performers, livelier neighbourhoods	Break-even calculator; pilot venue results
Originality	Supply-side taste AI; cross-domain concepts; nobody else closes the loop	Generic AI vs Encore toggle
Meaningful use of Qloo	Location, demographics, cross-domain affinity, popularity, entity search all drive decisions	"Powered by Qloo" panel listing every call in a run

The judges. Each one should see their own world in it: Boehly owns teams and venues, Cedric the Entertainer performs in rooms like these, Calacanis backs businesses with clear revenue, Diolosa will look at the depth of Qloo use, Seligman at trust and governance

(the grounding rule).

Scope, build plan and risks

The build runs in five gated phases from Oct 12 to Oct 29, leaving Oct 30 as a buffer. A phase does not end until its gate passes.

Five phases, each closed by a gate; submit a day early

De-risk Oct 12–13	Agent core Oct 14–18	Product Oct 19–23	Wow + pilot Oct 24–26	Ship Oct 27–29
Read the rules Get the Qloo key Test 3 venues	API tool wrappers 6-step pipeline Grounding check	Onboarding, trace Concept cards Calendar, kit, RSVP	Generic vs Encore Talent, ad brief Real venue pilot	Polish, demo data README, write-up Video, submit
Gate **Data is rich**	Gate **Plan in 90 s**	Gate **Full flow on phone**	Gate **Demo-ready app**	Gate **Submitted Oct 29**

Build plan · 5 phases, Oct 12–29

If the day-1 gate fails (Qloo location data is thin for the chosen areas), switch neighbourhoods or lean on interest signals before writing pipeline code.

Cut-list if behind schedule, in this order:

1. Learning loop (keep check-in counts, drop automatic adjustment)
2. Partner cross-promo suggestions
3. Talent outreach drafts (keep the shortlist)
4. Poster generation (keep the posts)

Never cut: the Generic vs Encore toggle, evidence chips with receipts, the live trace, preloaded demo venues, and live hosting.

Risks

Risk	Likelihood	Impact	Mitigation
Kenya not eligible, or prizes can't be paid there	Low–medium	Critical	Read the official rules on day 1; ask organisers on Devpost if unclear

Risk	Likelihood	Impact	Mitigation
Qloo location data thin for the chosen areas	Medium	High	Test 3 neighbourhoods on day 1; pick the richest US areas
Qloo rate limits or slow API key approval	Medium	High	Cache every response; precompute demo venues
Talent suggestions are famous, not bookable	High	Medium	Filter to lower popularity tiers; frame as "acts this crowd loves, book a local act in this style"
Agent states numbers Qloo never returned	Medium	High	Grounding validator drops any claim without a receipt
Long runs time out on Vercel	Medium	Medium	One server call per pipeline step, streamed
Solo scope creep	High	High	Daily gates and the cut-list above
No real pilot venue in time	Medium	Medium	Still submit; a friendly venue anywhere counts, labelled honestly

Demo script and submission checklist

The demo must make the case in two minutes without any explanation from Hopp.

Two-minute walkthrough

1. **0:00–0:15, the hook.** "This bar in Brooklyn is empty every Tuesday. Here's what a normal AI tells the owner." Show the generic answer: trivia night.
2. **0:15–0:45, Encore runs.** Same venue, live trace: neighbourhood read, competitor gap, concepts forming.
3. **0:45–1:10, the evidence.** Open a concept card. Tap an evidence chip to show the actual Qloo result behind it.
4. **1:10–1:35, execution.** Pick the concept: 4-week calendar, talent shortlist, poster and posts appear.
5. **1:35–1:50, the door.** Show the event page, an RSVP, and a QR check-in updating the dashboard.

6. **1:50–2:00, the business.** Break-even calculator and pilot venue result, if available. Close: "Qloo knows the taste. Encore fills the room."

Submission checklist

- [ ] Live URL works on desktop and phone, in a logged-out browser
- [ ] 3 preloaded demo venues return results instantly
- [ ] Public repo, MIT licence, README with setup, architecture and Qloo usage
- [ ] Devpost write-up: problem, solution, how Qloo is used (endpoint by endpoint), architecture, challenges, what's next
- [ ] Screenshots of trace, concept card, launch kit, dashboard
- [ ] 2-minute video uploaded
- [ ] Pilot venue result and owner quote, if available
- [ ] Submitted by Oct 29; Oct 30 kept free for fixes